

and sturdy surface to set the computer on. The place should have enough room to accommodate all components that will be needed. Also, ensure the location is near a grounded outlet, so you can test your computer if needed during and after component installation.

If this is the first time you're going to fiddle with the innards of your computer and if all your previous upgrades having been done by your hardware engineer, get a blank sheet of paper. Now, get to the back of the computer and check everything out. At first sight, everything may look alien to you, but what you need to do is draw a rough sketch of the back of the computer and then trace the wires or cables to the various devices they are connected to. This will help when reassembling the machine. In older computers, colour coding is absent, and this will help even more.

Manuals play a crucial role. If your computer is old, you may have lost the manuals. It would be a good idea, though, to locate whatever you can, and keep it handy.

Before you touch the insides, make sure that all cables including the network, phone and power cables have been detached, and that the computer is free from anything attached to it—including the speakers, keyboard, mouse, and any USB devices.

You may want to think about stuff outside the box that needs upgrading—keyboards, printers and such. Here's a brief digression on these before we get to opening up the box.